Nursing Essentials

Priority: Severe blood pressure or neurologic symptoms need urgent escalation during pregnancy and after birth.

FOCUS 1

Recognize

- **After 20 weeks:** new hypertension plus proteinuria or qualifying organ dysfunction can indicate preeclampsia.
- **Protein is not required:** thrombocytopenia, renal / liver injury, pulmonary edema, or neurologic findings can establish concern.
- **Severe-range BP:** systolic at least 160 or diastolic at least 110 mm Hg. Promptly reassess and activate the urgent treatment pathway.

FOCUS 2

Assess severity

- **Ask:** persistent severe headache, vision changes, epigastric / right-upper-quadrant pain, or dyspnea.
- **Trend:** blood pressure, neurologic findings, urine output, platelets, creatinine, and liver tests as ordered.
- **HELLP:** hemolysis, elevated liver enzymes, and low platelets; assess the overall picture, not proteinuria alone.

FOCUS 3

Treat

- **Antihypertensives:** ordered therapy addresses severe blood pressure and stroke risk; do not delay for routine reassessment intervals.
- **Magnesium:** prevents / treats seizures; monitor respiration, reflexes, output, and signs of toxicity.
- **Birth planning:** depends on severity, gestational age, and maternal / fetal condition. Monitor fluid balance carefully.

If seizure or toxicity occurs

Make it stick: Birth does not immediately remove the risk. New postpartum headache, visual symptoms, dyspnea, or severe BP deserves urgent assessment.

Focus	What to know	Nursing application
Eclamptic seizure	call for help, protect from injury, support airway / oxygenation, and use lateral positioning when feasible.	Protect airway and safety
Avoid	restraining the client or placing objects in the mouth.	Prevent additional injury
Magnesium toxicity	stop the infusion, escalate, support ventilation, and prepare ordered calcium gluconate.	Stop the infusion and escalate

RED FLAGS · ESCALATE PROMPTLY

Severe-range blood pressure, seizure, pulmonary edema symptoms, severe headache, vision changes, or persistent upper-abdominal pain needs urgent escalation.